STATISTICS & MACHINE LEARNING · LESSON 13 OF 28

Logistic Regression: Probabilities, Odds Ratios and Credit-Risk Scoring

Classify with probabilities. The sigmoid and log-odds, maximum likelihood and log loss, fitting logistic regression with statsmodels (inference, odds ratios) and scikit-learn (pipelines, regularisation), thresholds and decisions, multiclass logistic regression, and scoring new applicants in the Bank Loans case study.

● Python class 16 · ML class 4 | ✦ statsmodels 0.1x · scikit-learn 1.7+ | Intermediate | ⏱ 120 min

By the end of this lesson you can

- Explain why linear regression fails for binary targets and how the sigmoid fixes it
- Interpret coefficients as log-odds and odds ratios
- Fit, evaluate and regularise logistic regression in statsmodels and scikit-learn
- Choose a probability threshold from business costs
- Score new applicants and explain a prediction

Datasets used

`bank_loans.csv`

The case: who will default?

A bank has 700 past borrowers with a known outcome (`default` = 1 if they failed to repay) and 150 new applicants with unknown outcomes. Features: age, education level (`ed` 1–5), years with current employer (`employ`), years at current address (`address`), income (thousands), debt-to-income ratio % (`debtinc`), credit-card debt and other debt (thousands).

Python

```python
import pandas as pd, numpy as np
b = pd.read_csv("bank_loans.csv")
known, new = b[b.default.notna()].copy(), b[b.default.isna()].copy()
known["default"] = known.default.astype(int)
print(len(known), "labelled |", len(new), "new applicants | default rate",
round(known.default.mean(), 3))
print(known.groupby("default")[["age", "employ", "address", "income", "debtinc",
"creddebt", "othdebt"]].mean().round(2))
```

OUTPUT

```
700 labelled | 150 new applicants | default rate 0.321
           age  employ  address  income  debtinc  creddebt  othdebt
default
0        39.69    7.61     6.29   50.94     8.55      1.47     2.96
1        32.67    3.45     3.29   46.30    13.17      2.31     3.99
```

Defaulters are younger, have shorter employment and address histories, and much higher debt-to-income ratios.

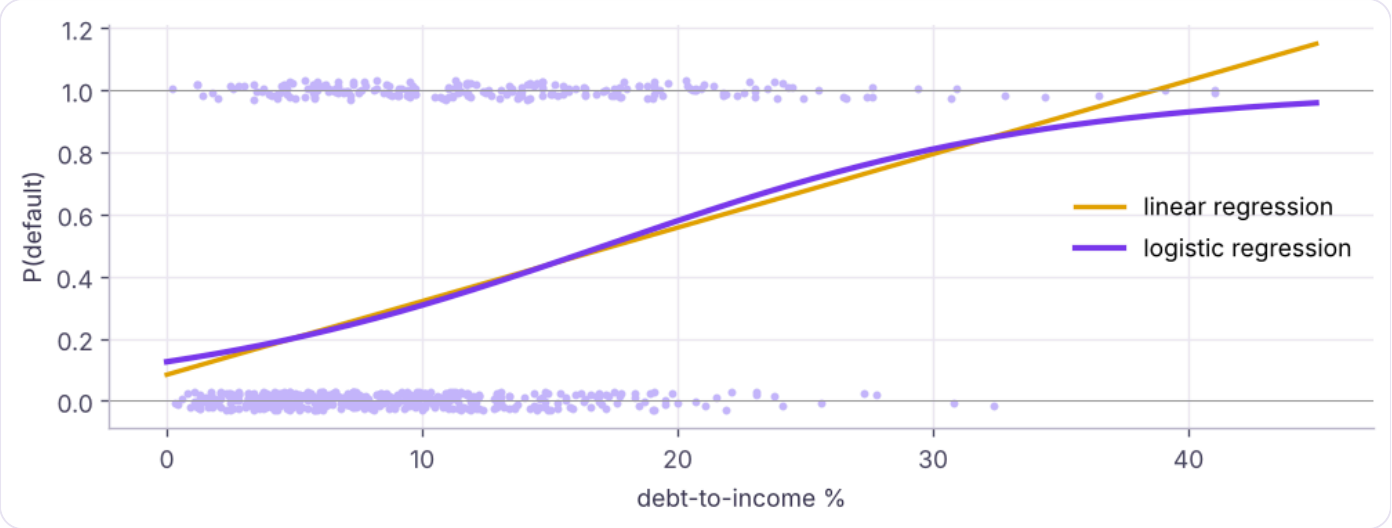
Why not linear regression?

A straight line predicts values below 0 and above 1, which are not probabilities. **Logistic regression** passes a linear score through the **sigmoid**:

$$p = P(y = 1 \mid x) = \frac{1}{1 + e^{-(\beta_0 + \beta_1 x_1 + \ \dots \ + \beta_k x_k)}}$$

Equivalently, the **log-odds** (logit) is linear in the features:

$$\log \frac{p}{1 - p} = \beta_0 + \beta_1 x_1 + \ \dots \ + \beta_k x_k$$



Linear regression vs logistic regression on default vs debt-to-income: the sigmoid keeps predictions between 0 and 1.

Fitting and interpreting with statsmodels

Logistic regression is fitted by **maximum likelihood**: choose coefficients that make the observed outcomes most probable, equivalently minimising **log loss** (cross-entropy).

Python

```
import statsmodels.formula.api as smf
m = smf.logit("default ~ age + ed + employ + address + income + debtinc + creddebt +
othdebt", data=known).fit(disp=0)
print(m.summary2().tables[1][["Coef.", "Std.Err.", "P>|z|"]].round(4))
print(f"pseudo R² (McFadden) {m.prsquared:.3f} | log-likelihood {m.llf:.1f}")
```

OUTPUT

```
             Coef.  Std.Err.    P>|z|
Intercept -0.5739    0.5772  0.3201
age       -0.0099    0.0137  0.4688
ed         0.0066    0.0989  0.9465
employ    -0.1586    0.0287  0.0000
address   -0.1021    0.0292  0.0005
income    -0.0014    0.0084  0.8687
debtinc    0.1067    0.0330  0.0012
creddebt   0.3246    0.1227  0.0081
othdebt   -0.0563    0.0579  0.3304
pseudo R² (McFadden) 0.244 | log-likelihood -332.3
```

Python

```
odds = pd.DataFrame({"odds_ratio": np.exp(m.params), "ci_low": np.exp(m.conf_int()[0]),
"ci_high": np.exp(m.conf_int()[1]), "p": m.pvalues}).drop("Intercept").round(3)
print(odds.sort_values("odds_ratio"))
```

OUTPUT

	odds_ratio	ci_low	ci_high	p
employ	0.853	0.807	0.903	0.000
address	0.903	0.853	0.956	0.000
othdebt	0.945	0.844	1.059	0.330
age	0.990	0.964	1.017	0.469
income	0.999	0.982	1.015	0.869
ed	1.007	0.829	1.222	0.946
debtinc	1.113	1.043	1.187	0.001
creddebt	1.384	1.088	1.760	0.008

Coefficient	Odds ratio e^β	Reading
β = 0	1	No association
β > 0	> 1	Higher odds of default per unit
β < 0	< 1	Lower odds of default per unit

For example, the odds ratio of about 0.85 for `employ` means each extra year with the current employer multiplies the odds of default by 0.85 (about 15% lower odds), holding the other variables constant. The odds ratio of about 1.38 for `creddebt` means each extra unit of card debt (₹1,000s) multiplies the odds by 1.38, and each extra point of debt-to-income raises the odds by about 11%. Age, education, income and other debt are not significant once the others are included.

> **NOTE** **Odds are not probabilities**
>
> Odds = p / (1 − p). A probability of 0.2 is odds of 0.25 ("1 to 4"). An odds ratio describes a *multiplicative* change in odds; the change in probability depends on where you start.

A reduced model keeps the significant predictors (a common credit-scoring practice: fewer, stable variables):

Python

```
m2 = smf.logit("default ~ employ + address + debtinc + creddebt", data=known).fit(disp=0)
print(m2.params.round(3).to_dict(), "| AIC full", round(m.aic, 1), "vs reduced",
round(m2.aic, 1))
```

OUTPUT

```
{'Intercept': -0.829, 'employ': -0.175, 'address': -0.113, 'debtinc': 0.099,
'creddebt': 0.25} | AIC full 682.6 vs reduced 677.0
```

Lower AIC is better (it balances fit and complexity), so the four-variable model is preferred.

scikit-learn pipeline with regularisation

Python

```python
from sklearn.model_selection import train_test_split, cross_val_score
from sklearn.pipeline import make_pipeline
from sklearn.preprocessing import StandardScaler
from sklearn.metrics import roc_auc_score, accuracy_score, log_loss, classification_report
feats = ["age", "ed", "employ", "address", "income", "debtinc", "creddebt", "othdebt"]
X, y = known[feats], known.default
Xtr, Xte, ytr, yte = train_test_split(X, y, test_size=0.25, stratify=y, random_state=7)
for C in (0.01, 0.1, 1, 100):
    pipe = make_pipeline(StandardScaler(), LogisticRegression(C=C, max_iter=1000))
    cv = cross_val_score(pipe, Xtr, ytr, cv=5, scoring="roc_auc").mean()
    print(f"C = {C:<5} 5-fold ROC-AUC {cv:.3f}")
clf = make_pipeline(StandardScaler(), LogisticRegression(C=1, max_iter=1000)).fit(Xtr, ytr)
proba = clf.predict_proba(Xte)[:, 1]
print(f"\ntest: ROC-AUC {roc_auc_score(yte, proba):.3f} | accuracy {accuracy_score(yte,
clf.predict(Xte)):.3f} | log loss {log_loss(yte, proba):.3f}")
print(classification_report(yte, clf.predict(Xte), target_names=["repaid", "default"],
digits=3))
```

OUTPUT

```
C = 0.01  5-fold ROC-AUC 0.791
C = 0.1   5-fold ROC-AUC 0.791
C = 1     5-fold ROC-AUC 0.793
C = 100   5-fold ROC-AUC 0.792

test: ROC-AUC 0.865 | accuracy 0.817 | log loss 0.431
              precision    recall  f1-score   support

      repaid      0.822     0.933     0.874       119
     default      0.800     0.571     0.667        56

    accuracy                          0.817       175
   macro avg      0.811     0.752     0.770       175
weighted avg      0.815     0.817     0.808       175
```

`C` is the inverse regularisation strength (lesson 12). Standardised coefficients from the pipeline are comparable across features:

Python

```
print(pd.Series(clf[-1].coef_[0], index=feats).round(3).sort_values().to_dict())
```

OUTPUT

```
{'employ': -0.875, 'address': -0.409, 'age': -0.148, 'othdebt': -0.025, 'income':
-0.018, 'ed': 0.014, 'creddebt': 0.339, 'debtinc': 0.59}
```

Choosing the threshold

`predict` uses a 0.5 threshold, but the right cut-off depends on costs. Suppose a missed defaulter costs the bank ₹50,000 and rejecting a good customer loses ₹10,000 of profit.

Python

```
from sklearn.metrics import confusion_matrix
cost_fn, cost_fp = 50_000, 10_000
rows = []
for t in np.arange(0.1, 0.91, 0.1):
    tn, fp, fn, tp = confusion_matrix(yte, (proba ≥ t).astype(int)).ravel()
    rows.append({"threshold": round(t, 1), "approved": tn + fn, "defaults_caught": tp,
"defaults_missed": fn, "good_rejected": fp, "cost_₹_lakh": (fn * cost_fn + fp * cost_fp) /
1e5})
th = pd.DataFrame(rows); print(th.to_string(index=False))
print("lowest-cost threshold:", th.loc[th["cost_₹_lakh"].idxmin(), "threshold"])
```

OUTPUT

```
 threshold  approved  defaults_caught  defaults_missed  good_rejected  cost_₹_lakh
       0.1        40               55                1             80          8.5
       0.2        72               51                5             52          7.7
       0.3        92               46               10             37          8.7
       0.4       118               41               15             16          9.1
       0.5       135               32               24              8         12.8
       0.6       152               19               37              4         18.9
       0.7       162               11               45              2         22.7
       0.8       167                8               48              0         24.0
       0.9       173                2               54              0         27.0
lowest-cost threshold: 0.2
```

When missing a defaulter is five times as costly as rejecting a good customer, the best threshold is well below 0.5. Lesson 14 formalises this with precision, recall and ROC curves.

Scoring new applicants

Python

```
final = make_pipeline(StandardScaler(), LogisticRegression(C=1, max_iter=1000)).fit(X, y)
# refit on all labelled data
new["p_default"] = final.predict_proba(new[feats])[:, 1].round(3)
best_t = th.loc[th["cost_₹_lakh"].idxmin(), "threshold"]
new["decision"] = np.where(new.p_default ≥ best_t, "decline / review", "approve")
print(new.decision.value_counts().to_dict())
print(new.sort_values("p_default", ascending=False)[["customer_id", "age", "employ",
"debtinc", "creddebt", "p_default", "decision"]].head(5).to_string(index=False))
```

OUTPUT

```
{'decline / review': 84, 'approve': 66}
customer_id  age  employ  debtinc  creddebt  p_default         decision
      L0782   36       0     32.9      4.73      0.961 decline / review
      L0774   42       8     39.1      7.26      0.932 decline / review
      L0736   32       5     28.8      7.60      0.898 decline / review
      L0702   41       6     27.9      4.55      0.883 decline / review
      L0753   36       6     29.7      6.09      0.876 decline / review
```

Explaining one decision

Python

```
one = new.sort_values("p_default", ascending=False).iloc[0]
z = (one[feats].astype(float) - final[0].mean_) / final[0].scale_
contrib = pd.Series(z.values * final[-1].coef_[0],
index=feats).sort_values(ascending=False)
print(f"{one.customer_id}: P(default) {one.p_default:.2f}; log-odds contributions:",
contrib.round(2).to_dict())
```

OUTPUT

```
L0782: P(default) 0.96; log-odds contributions: {'debtinc': 2.37, 'employ': 0.97,
'creddebt': 0.96, 'address': 0.13, 'income': 0.03, 'age': 0.02, 'ed': -0.01,
'othdebt': -0.17}
```

Each contribution is a coefficient × the applicant's standardised value: positive values push towards default. This additive explanation is a big reason banks like logistic regression (and regulators

require explanations of adverse decisions).

Multiclass logistic regression

With more than two classes, scikit-learn fits a **multinomial** (softmax) model automatically: one score per class, converted to probabilities that sum to 1.

Python

```
from sklearn.datasets import load_iris
iris = load_iris(as_frame=True)
mc = make_pipeline(StandardScaler(), LogisticRegression(max_iter=1000)).fit(iris.data,
iris.target)
print(mc.predict_proba(iris.data.iloc[[0, 60, 120]]).round(3), "| classes:",
iris.target_names.tolist())
```

OUTPUT

```
[[0.985 0.015 0.   ]
 [0.022 0.962 0.016]
 [0.    0.023 0.977]] | classes: ['setosa', 'versicolor', 'virginica']
```

Summary

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- Logistic regression models log-odds as linear in the features and maps them to probabilities with the sigmoid; it is fitted by maximum likelihood (log loss).
- e^β is an odds ratio: > 1 raises, < 1 lowers the odds per unit, holding other features constant.
- statsmodels gives inference (p-values, CIs, AIC); scikit-learn gives pipelines, regularisation (C) and deployment.
- Choose the probability threshold from business costs, not by default 0.5.
- Coefficient × standardised value gives a transparent explanation of each prediction.

Quick quiz

6 questions · tap an answer to check it

1. What does the sigmoid function do?

- **A** Maps any real number to a probability between 0 and 1
- **B** Squares the errors
- **C** Selects features
- **D** Scales the data

Answer: A. 1 / (1 + e^(−z)).

2. An odds ratio of 1.38 for card debt means…

- **A** Each extra unit of card debt multiplies the odds of default by 1.38
- **B** Default probability rises by 1.38 points
- **C** Card debt causes default
- **D** 80% of customers default

Answer: A. Multiplicative change in odds.

3. Which loss does logistic regression minimise?

- **A** Mean squared error
- **B** Log loss (cross-entropy)
- **C** Hinge loss
- **D** MAE

Answer: B. Equivalent to maximising the likelihood.

4. Missing a defaulter costs 5× more than rejecting a good customer. The best threshold is probably...

- **A** Below 0.5
- **B** Exactly 0.5
- **C** Above 0.5
- **D** Irrelevant

Answer: A. Flag more applicants to avoid expensive misses.

5. In scikit-learn, LogisticRegression(C=0.01) means...

- **A** Strong regularisation
- **B** No regularisation
- **C** 1% threshold
- **D** 1% of the data

Answer: A. C is the inverse of the penalty strength.

6. Why do banks favour logistic regression for credit scoring?

- **A** It is accurate, stable and each decision can be explained by additive contributions
- **B** It is the newest algorithm
- **C** It never makes mistakes
- **D** It needs no data

Answer: A. Explainability is a regulatory requirement.

EXERCISE

Practice

(1) Fit a logistic regression for HR attrition with `overtime`, `job_satisfaction`, `years_at_company` and `monthly_income`. Report odds ratios. (2) What is the predicted probability for an employee with overtime, satisfaction 1, 1 year at the company and ₹50,000 income? (3) Find the threshold that maximises F1 on a validation split.

Show solution (worked answer)

Python

```
hr = pd.read_csv("hr_employees.csv"); hr["left"] = (hr.attrition == "Yes").astype(int)
ma = smf.logit("left ~ C(overtime) + job_satisfaction + years_at_company +
I(monthly_income / 10000)", data=hr).fit(disp=0)
print(np.exp(ma.params).round(3))
print(ma.predict(pd.DataFrame({"overtime": ["Yes"], "job_satisfaction": [1],
"years_at_company": [1], "monthly_income": [50000]})))
from sklearn.metrics import f1_score
ts = np.linspace(.05, .95, 19); print(max(ts, key=lambda t: f1_score(yte, proba ⩾
t)))
```

INTERVIEW CORNER

Questions you may be asked

Q: Why is it called regression if it classifies? It regresses the log-odds on the features; classification happens when you apply a threshold to the predicted probability.

Q: How do you interpret a logistic regression coefficient? A one-unit increase in the feature changes the log-odds by β, i.e. multiplies the odds by e^β, holding other features constant.

Q: What are the assumptions of logistic regression? Independent observations, a linear relationship between features and log-odds, little multicollinearity, no extreme outliers, and enough events per variable.

Practise more online

Free, trusted places to test yourself on this topic. Links open the original site in a new tab.